

Whales in the making

All land animals evolved from sea-dwelling ancestors that left the water and adapted to life on land. Whales are one of several groups of animals that then did the reverse and went back to the sea. They evolved from hoofed land mammals and are distantly related to cows and pigs, while their closest living land relative is the hippopotamus!



THE WALKING WHALE

Ambulocetus, an early member of the whale family, lived more than 50 million years ago. A bit like an otter, it was equally at home on land and in water. Its front feet had small hooves for walking on land, while its back feet served to propel it through the water. Its name means “walking whale.”

CLOSE COUSINS

The theory that whales are related to hippopotamuses was first suggested in 1870, but most scientists dismissed it as unlikely. More recently, careful comparison of whale DNA and hippo DNA has shown that hippos probably are the closest living relatives of whales.

► HIPPOS *spend much of their lives in water but are less aquatic than whales.*

